






Photographs by KRISHNA SINGH

**GRAND CONCEPTS**
**1.** The Vindhyavasini temple in Mirzapur **2.** The *parkauta* or parikrama path **3.** A house being demolished for the 50 ft wide parikrama path

or parikrama path and for the walls in the lanes that will surround the temple. Mirzapur district magistrate Divya Mittal says, "The construction work should be over soon. The corridor will open up more opportunities for spiritual tourism. Along with the corridor, we are also developing the ghats, for which Rs 88 crore has been sanctioned. To increase connectivity, we are planning to create a *jal marg* (waterways) link between Varanasi, Prayagraj and Mirzapur." A cable car service also connects the Vindhyavasini temple now with the Ashtabhuja and Kali Khoh temples, which complete the famous 'trikon' temples of the region.

Work on the two other temple corridors, Mathura and Bareilly, is, however, yet to start. The Mathura corridor project was proposed last year but is tangled up in legal issues.

**ONCE THE TEMPLE CORRIDOR WORK IS DONE, THE VINDHYAVASINI SHRINE WILL BE ABLE TO HOST 5,000 DEVOTEES AT ANY GIVEN TIME**

The government was planning to acquire five acres of land adjacent to the Banke Bihari temple in Mathura but the temple trustees and locals have moved the Supreme Court against the proposed development plan, asking the court to intervene and save the "temple's heritage". One of the claims made in the petition is that the rights of the priests, the Goswamis who have overseen the temple for centuries, are being violated and that they have not got a fair hearing. In January, the locals sent 108 letters written in blood to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and CM Adityanath to register their protest. The state government is awaiting the court's decision now.

Coming to the Bareilly Nath corridor, Yogi, who also belongs to the Nath sect, has said that it would "link the seven mystical Nath (Shiva) temples" nestled in the city. These are the Alakhnath, Madhinath, Tapeshwar Nath, Dhopeshwar Nath, Pashupatinath, Bankhandinath and Trivati Nath temples. As part of the project, all the Shiva temples in the region will now get a facelift. Apart from the tourism-related developments, the Bareilly Development Authority will also build a six-lane road for the corridor. Land acquisition work has already begun. Things have got off to a holy start. ■